

“The earth [was] **churned** into a **moonscape** by ... US bombs.”

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KEY CONCEPT

CLOSE AIR SUPPORT

Khe Sanh provided many classic examples of Close Air Support (CAS), the battlefield doctrine of calling in air strikes against enemy positions located near your own lines. Carried out with helicopter gunships, fighter jets, and B-52 bombers, CAS was essential to American survival at Khe Sanh and Hue. Key to the concept is the use of Forward Air Controllers (FACs), small teams that assess the situation on the ground and advise the air units on where to strike. At the siege of Khe Sanh, B-52 crews relied on ground-force radar to direct them to their targets.



» AFTER

Khe Sanh and the wider Tet Offensive marked a watershed in the war.

POLICY CHANGE

Following Khe Sanh, General Westmoreland ordered US troops to **abandon combat bases** along the McNamara Line. Shortly afterward, in June 1968, Westmoreland was replaced as commander of the MACV by **General Creighton Abrams**, who introduced **Vietnamization**—the policy of equipping and training ARVN troops to take on more of the combat.

ROUTE 9

In February 1971, Khe Sanh and Route 9 were reopened in preparation for **the invasion of Laos by ARVN troops**.

ECOLOGICAL IMPACT

In addition to the cost in human lives, bombing and napalm **destroyed much of the rainforest surrounding Khe Sanh**. Over the decades, the jungle reclaimed many of the bomb craters while much of the military ordnance left on the battlefield was collected and sold or repurposed by the hilltribes of the area.